

FIONA CHEN

fionachen@g.harvard.edu

(512) 461-8414

<https://fion.ac/>



HARVARD UNIVERSITY

Littauer Center
1805 Cambridge St
Cambridge MA 02138

Placement Director: Myrto Kalouptsidi
Placement Director: Oleg Itskhoki
Administrative Director: Brenda Piquet

myrto@g.harvard.edu
itskhoki@fas.harvard.edu
bpiquet@harvard.edu

(617) 496-0832
(617) 495-2144
(617) 495-8927

Education

Harvard University

Ph.D. in Business Economics, 2021 to 2027 (expected)

Visiting Student, Stanford Digital Economy Lab, 2026

M.A. in Business Economics, 2023

Massachusetts Institute of Technology

B.S. in Mathematics and in Economics, 2021

Fields

Labor Economics
Personnel Economics
Digital Economics and AI

References

Lawrence Katz
Harvard University
lkatz@harvard.edu

Jesse Shapiro
Harvard University
jesse.m.shapiro@gmail.com

Amanda Pallais
Harvard University
apallais@fas.harvard.edu

Erik Brynjolfsson
Stanford University
erikb@stanford.edu

Affiliations

Stanford Digital Economy Lab	2026-
Social Finance Institute	2025-
Opportunity Insights	2021-

Job Market Paper

Artificial Intelligence in the Firm: Bottlenecks in Software Production, with James Stratton

We study the impacts of AI coding assistants and agents on software engineering work, using a novel proprietary dataset from an engineering analytics platform, covering 300 million work events – including GitHub coding activity, Jira issues, and Google Calendar events – across 718 firms. We use a staggered difference-in-differences design, exploiting variation in firm-level adoption timing of AI coding assistants and agents. Both technologies increase coding productivity. However, productivity gains do not fully pass through to changes in software output or employment. For AI agents, this incomplete pass-through reflects a bottleneck from code review: review times increase, a larger share of code updates require revisions, and reviews involve more comments. We develop a model of software production to rationalize these results, in which AI affects both productivity and quality of intermediate outputs, and in turn can generate a review bottleneck and limit pass-through.

Papers in Progress

Task Assignment and Career Advancement, with James Stratton

Workers with the same job title often perform vastly different tasks – but how do differences in task assignment affect career advancement? We examine this question using data from an engineering analytics platform on tasks assigned to software engineers, merged with LinkedIn data on workers' career trajectories. Using an instrumental variables approach, we exploit quasi-random variation in task assignment arising from fluctuations in teams' task portfolios at the time workers join. Assignment to more complex tasks in the first quarter of employment significantly increases

the likelihood of promotion within two years, consistent with greater opportunities for human capital accumulation and ability signaling. We explore the role of task assignment in gender disparities, documenting substantial gender differences in task assignment and persistent gender gaps in promotion.

AI as a Career Advisor, with Katelyn Cranney and Leo Saenger

We examine the role of AI in the job search process in partnership with CareerVillage, a nonprofit organization that provides AI-powered career guidance through its conversational tool, COACH. Specifically, we study whether AI can improve career decision-making by facilitating structured self-reflection, helping workers understand and articulate their skills and preferences, and evaluate tradeoffs across career options. We begin by using observational data to characterize how workers use COACH, finding that many conversations center on self-reflection. We are currently conducting a randomized controlled trial with unemployed job seekers to estimate the effects of AI-assisted self-reflection on career decision-making, employment outcomes, and longer-run job satisfaction.

The Labor Market Effects of AI: Current Evidence and Future Directions, with Erik Brynjolfsson and Bharat Chandar

How have generative AI technologies affected labor market outcomes? This question has attracted significant attention from economists and policymakers. We review and synthesize the emerging theoretical and empirical literature on the labor market impacts of generative AI. We organize the empirical evidence into three broad approaches: adoption-based studies comparing early and late adopters, exposure-based studies comparing occupations with differing levels of AI exposure, and survey-based evidence on workers' and firms' responses to AI. While exposure-based studies generally document declines in employment in AI-exposed occupations, the evidence from adoption-based studies and surveys is more mixed. We develop a framework for interpreting these findings by distinguishing between anticipation effects, automation effects, and the roles of partial and general equilibrium adjustments.

Policy Papers	Shaping the Future of Work: Generative AI, Inequality, and Opportunity , <i>The Social Finance Institute: Workforce and Economic Mobility Papers</i> , 17 December 2025	
Employment & Service	MIT Corporation (Board of Trustees), <i>Trustee</i>	2021-26
	Social Finance, <i>Research Fellow</i>	2025-26
	Federal Reserve Bank of San Francisco, <i>Financial Supervision Intern</i>	2019
Fellowships & Awards	Schmidt Sciences AI at Work Grant	2026
	Stripe Economics of AI Fellowship	2025
	J. Robert Beyster Fellowship, Study of Employee Ownership and Profit Sharing	2025
	James M. and Cathleen D. Stone Fellowship in Inequality and Wealth Concentration	2023
	Opportunity Insights Doctoral Fellowship	2021
	Paul and Daisy Soros Fellowship for New Americans	2021
	Phi Beta Kappa	2021
	Rhodes Scholarship Finalist	2021
Research Assistance	Burchard Scholarship	2019
	Harvard, RA to Winnie van Dijk, <i>Concentration in Rental Housing Markets</i>	2022-23
	MIT, RA to Amy Finkelstein, <i>Blueprints for Universal Health Coverage</i>	2019-20
	MIT, RA to David Autor, <i>New Frontiers: The Origins and Evolving Content of New Work</i>	2019-20
Teaching	MIT, RA to Frank Schilbach, <i>The Economic Consequences of Increasing Sleep Among the Urban Poor</i>	2017-19
	Harvard Medical School, Causal Inference in Economics and Medicine, <i>Joshua Angrist</i>	2025
	Harvard, ECON 980B Education in the Economy, <i>Claudia Goldin and Lawrence Katz</i>	2024
	Harvard, ECON 2330 History and Human Capital (PhD), <i>Claudia Goldin and Lawrence Katz</i>	2024
	Harvard, ECON 980X The Economics of Work and Family, <i>Claudia Goldin</i>	2023
	Harvard, Math Camp: Econometrics (PhD)	2023

	MIT, 14.75 Political Economy and Economic Development, <i>Benjamin Olken</i>	2021
	MIT, 14.13 Psychology and Economics, <i>Frank Schilbach and Dmitry Taubinsky</i>	2020
Seminars & Conferences	INFORMS Annual Conference (Scheduled), INFORMS Manufacturing & Service Operations Management, Society of Labor Economists, Google, MIT FutureTech, Stanford Labor/Public Student Workshop, Stanford University Digital Economy Lab	2026
	UC Berkeley Artificial Intelligence Research (BAIR) Laboratory, MIT Computer Science and AI Laboratory (CSAIL), Opportunity Insights Conference, University of Chicago Machine Learning in Economics Conference, Harvard Kennedy School Stone Scholar Symposium	2025
Languages	English (Native), Mandarin (Conversational), French (Basic)	
Software	Python, R, Stata, SQL	